

NARENDRA MODI CROSSED a personal landmark on October 7, 2021. He completed an uninterrupted 20 years as head of democratically elected governments—12 and a half years as the chief minister of Gujarat and over seven years and running as the prime minister of India. By the time he wound up his tenure in Gujarat to move to New Delhi in 2014, in a spectacular capture of power and the popular imagination, he had already been its longest-serving chief minister. Now, he is the longest-serving non-Congress prime minister, having overtaken Atal Bihari Vajpayee's record of six years. Other chief ministers, be it the late Jyoti Basu in West Bengal or Pawan Kumar Chamling in Sikkim, have served more than 20 years in their respective states, but none of them has had the rare privilege of being both chief minister and prime minister for a long period as Narendra Modi has.

What this gives him is a unique mix of experience and perspective, conferring on him the ability to handle any crisis that comes his way. Few heads of state anywhere in the world have had to confront the multiple challenges he had to face in his second term as prime minister. Not since World War II has there been the kind of devastation that the Covid-19 pandemic wreaked on nations. India faced the brunt of it, with over 43 million reported cases and at least half a million deaths. Its economy lay in tatters, with GDP growth turning negative for the first time in 50 years. Unemployment soared, with an estimated half of those employed in the informal sector losing their jobs.

Worse was to come. China violated every treaty it had signed with India in recent decades when it breached the Line of Actual Control in the summer of 2020, committing an aggression that saw the loss of armed personnel in a conflict between the two countries for the first time since 1975. And just when the Indian economy appeared to be recovering, Russia invaded Ukraine in February, starting a war that has been devastating for global trade and debilitating for the Indian economy. Wholesale inflation at 15 per cent is the highest in two decades. Fuel prices have shot up by 15 per cent and cooking oil by an average 60 per cent. India has been hurting, and badly so.

Those who know him well see an element of continuity from Modi 1.0 in how he deals with such cataclysmic developments. For instance, he continues to be a good listener, who considers all points of view and asks probing questions of experts before taking a decision, and stays the course once he has made up his mind. If Modi 2.0 is different, it's in how the prime minister has overcome many of the hesitancies of his first term and initiated radical reforms in key sectors even in the face of the systemic shocks brought by the pandemic. Dr P.K. Mishra, principal secretary to the prime minister, who has worked with Modi since his Gujarat days, told India Today, "The prime minister has a larger perspective of the many unprecedented challenges the country faces because